his opponents, Gaius Julius Polybius, ran with the slogan ‘Elect Gaius Julius Polybius to the office of *aedile*. He provides good bread.’

There were also endorsements by religious groups and professional associations, such as ‘The worshippers of Isis demand the election of Gnaeus Helvius Sabinus’ and ‘All the mule drivers request that you elect Gaius Julius Polybius.’ There was dirty work, too. Someone who clearly wasn’t Marcus Cerrinius Vatia drew the graffiti ‘All the drunkards ask you to elect Marcus Cerrinius Vatia’ and ‘The petty thieves ask you to elect Vatia.’[33] Such electioneering indicates that the position of aedile had power in Pompeii and that the aedile was chosen in relatively free and fair elections, rather than appointed by the imperial autocrat in Rome.

Even in empires whose rulers never had any democratic pretensions, democracy could still flourish in local settings. In the Tsarist Empire, for example, the daily lives of millions of villagers were managed by rural communes. Going back at least to the eleventh century, each commune usually included fewer than a thousand people. They were subject to a landlord and bore many obligations to their lord and to the central tsarist state, but they had considerable autonomy in managing their internal affairs and in deciding how to discharge their external obligations, such as paying taxes and providing military recruits. The commune mediated local disputes, provided emergency relief, enforced social norms, oversaw the distribution of land to individual households and regulated access to shared resources like forests and pastures. Decisions on important matters were made in communal meetings in which the heads of local households expressed their views and chose the commune’s elder. Resolutions at least tried to reflect the majority’s will.[34]

In tsarist villages and Roman cities a form of democracy was possible because a meaningful public conversation was possible. Pompeii was a city of about eleven thousand people in 79 CE,[35] so everybody could supposedly judge for themselves whether Lucretius Fronto was an honest man and whether Marcus Cerrinius Vatia was a drunken thief. But democracy at a scale of millions became possible only in the modern age, when mass media changed the nature of large-scale information networks.